Welcome to

GENERAL PSYCHOLOGY CLASS

INSTRUCTOR: MENGESHA NIGUS.

Ground Rules

- *1 hour lecture followed by student questions and answers*
- *15 minute break (get a snack!)*
- *Another 1 hour lecture followed by student questions and answers*
- *Then the end of class for today*

UNIT ONE

INTRODUCTION TO PSYCHOLOGY



INSTRUCTOR: MENGESHA N.

Overview

- ***Definition of Basic Concepts***
- ***Goals of Psychology***
- ***Historical Background of Psychology***
- ***Major Perspective in Psychology***
- ***Branches of Psychology***
- ***Research Methods in Psychology***

Meaning and Definition of Psychology

- The word “Psychology "comes from the two Greek words. These are:

✓ ***psyche***, which translates as **“soul”** or “sprit”, ”mind” and

✓ ***logos***, which means the **study,** knowledge or discourse.

“the study of the **mind/soul/sprit**”

represented by the Greek letter Ψ (psi) which is read as("sy")

psychology *is a scientific study of behavior and its underlying mental process of human beings and animals.*

Key words in the definition

Science

- ✓ Follow scientific procedures and use empirical data to study behavior and mental processes.
- ✓ Psychology does not rely on common sense or speculation

Behavior

- ✓ All of our out ward or overt actions and reactions such as talking, facial expressions, movement ,etc.
- ✓ There is also covert behavior which is hidden, non-observable and generally considered as a mental process

Mental processes

- ✓ Refer to all the internal, covert activities of our minds, such as thinking, feeling, remembering, etc.
- ✓ Psychologists strive to understand the ***mysteries of human nature***—why people **think**, **feel**, and **act** as they do

Psychologists also study **animal behavior**;

It purposes:

- ✓ It is **ethically forbidden** to conduct experiment on human beings.
- ✓ Conclusions obtained from experiments on animal behavior are usually **applicable** to human behavior
- ✓To formulate **theories**, **laws** & **principles** that govern human behavior
- ✓To determine **laws of behavior** that apply to all organisms

Review

- "Scientific study of behavior and its causes."

  –Overt (directly observable) and covert behaviors

- Psychologists study:
  - How you act (behavior/overt)
  - How you think (mental/covert)
  - How you feel (covert & overt)
  - How your brain and body respond (physiological/covert)



Goals of Psychology

- ✓**Description**: what is happening?
- ✓**Explanation**: why it is happening?
- ✓**Prediction**: When will it happen again?
- ✓ **Controlling**: How can it be changed?

Description

- ✓ it involves observing the behavior and noticing everything about it.
- ✓ Every behaviour has its own way of occurring
- ✓ In describing behaviour, a psychologist focuses on how behaviour occurs.
- ✓ It is a search for answers for questions like
- ✓ What is happening? Where does it happen? To whom does it happen?‘ And under what circumstances does it seem to happen?.

Explanation

- ✓ In explanation of behaviour, a psychologist becomes concerned about **why behaviour occurs as it does**
- ✓ Every behaviour has its own causes. No behaviour occurs without a cause.
- ✓ It is about trying to **find reasons** for the observed behavior.
- ✓ This helps in the process of forming theories of behavior (A theory is a general explanation of a set of observations or facts).

Prediction

- ✓ Prediction is about determining **what will happen in the future**
- ✓ involves forecasting the likelihood of a behaviour under certain circumstances.
- ✓ Prediction of behaviours is possible through the use of **theories or principles**

Control (Modification)

- ✓ **How can it be changed?** Control or modify or change the behavior from undesirable one to a desirable one).
- ✓ involves changing a behaviour which is anti social or unacceptable.
- ✓ For healthy functioning of society and the individual, these kind of negative (maladaptive) behaviours should be avoided
- ✓ In psychology, there are psychological techniques to help an individual avoid a maladaptive behaviour.

Historical Roots of Psychology

- Psychology has its roots in **philosophy** and **physiology**
- **Philosophers** had asked questions about human emotions, thoughts and behavior. They had tried to deduce answers to their questions by applying logic and common sense reasoning philosophers did not always make deduction successfully.
- **who contributed to the Development of Psychology**
  - ✓Hippocrates (460-377 B.C)- emotion(body humor)
  - ✓Plato (428-348 B.C)_intelligence (inborn/inherited)
  - ✓Aristotle (382-322 B.C)_thinking (heart)
  - ✓Rene Descartes (1556-1650 A.D)_mind/body
  - ✓John Locke (English Philosopher)_tabula rasa

- ✓ **Empiricists** (a group of philosophers who believed a pursuit of truth through observation and experience)
- ✓ **Nativism** (group of philosophers who believed a knowledge is inborn or inherited)
- **Physiologists** were especially influential in providing a new understanding of the brain and the nervous system, and the way in which these structures affect behavior.

It was the union between the questions asked by the philosophers and the careful scientific experimentation of the physiologists that led to the field of study we call psychology.

Major Perspective in Psychology

Early Schools of Psychology

Structuralism

- developed by Edward Bradford Titchener.
- Wilhelm Wundt, who established the first scientific laboratory of psychology in Leipzig in 1879, and believed that human mind could be scientifically studied.
- Task of Psychology

–is to **identify the basic elements of consciousness (image, feelings & sensation)**

–to find out the units or elements, which make up the mind

- Methods: *Introspection (*looking in ward into our consciousness*)*

Functionalism

- founded by William James (1848-1910) which proposed that, the *function of the mind*, not the structure.

Task of Psychology

✓is to investigate the function, or purpose, of consciousness rather than its structure

✓psychological processes are **adaptive**. They allow humans to survive and to adapt successfully to their surroundings.

Method

✓questionnaires, mental tests and objective descriptions of behavior

Gestalt psychology

- Founders of this schools of thought are
  - ✓ *Max Wertheimer (1880-1943)*

Task of Psychology

✓mind should be thought of as resulting from the whole pattern

✓Psychology as a study of the **whole mind**

✓Argued that the mind is not made up of combinations of elements.

✓The mind should be thought of as a result of the whole pattern of sensory activity and the relationships and organizations within their pattern

Methods

✓ *are Naïve Introspection and experimentation*

Behaviorism

- Founder-**John B. Watson** (1878-1958)

Task of psychology

✓Behaviorists view psychology as a study of observable and measurable **behaviors**.

✓Three important characteristics; conditioned response, learned rather than unlearned behaviors, and focus on animal behavior

Methods

- are Observation and Experimentation

Psychoanalysis

- founded by a Viennese physician **Sigmund Freud (1856-1939).**

Task of Psychology

✓ psychology studies about the components of the unconscious part of the human mind.

✓The unconscious which is the subject matter of psychoanalysis contains hidden wishes, passions, guilty secrets, unspeakable yearnings, and conflict between desire and duty.

Methods

- free association, dream interpretation, analysis of slip of tongue, jokes, and Transference

The mind is like an iceberg in that only a small part of its substance is visible

Modern Perspectives in Psychology

Psychodynamic perspective

- ✓ It has its origins in ***Freud's theory*** of psychoanalysis, but many other psychodynamic theories exist.
- ✓ This perspective emphasizes the ***unconscious dynamics*** within the individual such as inner forces, conflicts or instinctual energy.
- ✓ The psychodynamic approach emphasizes:
  - The influence of unconscious mental behavior on every day behavior
  - The role of ***childhood experiences*** in shaping adult personality
  - The role of ***intrapersonal conflict*** in determining human behavior
- Psychodynamic perspective tries to dig below the surface of a person's behavior to get into unconscious motives
- Psychodynamists think of themselves as ***archaeologists of the mind.***

Behavioral Perspective

- It emphasizes the role *learning experiences* play in shaping the behavior of an organism.
- It is concerned with how the environment affects the person‘s actions.
- Behaviorists focus on environmental conditions(e.g. rewards, and punishments) that maintain or discourage specific behaviors.
- Also called the *"black box“* approach in psychology because it treats the mind as less useful in understanding human behavior and focus on what goes into and out of the box, but not on the processes that take place inside
- This means, behaviorists are only interested in the effects of the environment (input) on behavior (output) but not in the process inside the box.

Humanistic Perspective

- ✓ Human behavior is not determined either by unconscious dynamics or the environment.
- ✓ Rather it emphasizes the *uniqueness of human beings* and focuses on human values and subjective experiences.
- ✓ This perspective places greater importance on the individual's ***free will.***
- ✓ The goal of humanistic psychology was helping people to *express themselves creatively and achieve their full potential or self- actualization* (developing the human potential to its fullest).

Cognitive Perspective

- It emphasizes what goes on in people's **heads**; how people reason, remember, understand language, solve problems, explain experiences and form beliefs.
- This perspective is concerned about the **mental processes.**
- The most important contribution of this perspective has been to show *how people's thoughts and explanations affect their actions, feelings, and choices*.
- Techniques used to explore behavior from a cognitive perspective include *electrical recording of brain activity, electrical stimulation and radioactive tracing of metabolic activity in the nervous system*.

Biological Perspective

- It focuses on studying how bodily events or *functioning of the body* affects behavior, feelings, and thoughts.
- It holds that the *brain and the various brain chemicals* affect psychological processes such as learning, performance, perception of reality, the experience of emotions, etc.
- This perspective underscores that *biology and behavior interact in a complex way*; biology affecting behavior and behavior in turn affecting biology.
- It also emphasizes the idea that we are ***physical beings*** who evolved over along time and that genetic heritage can predispose us to behaving in a certain way.

Socio-cultural Perspective

- It focuses on the *social and cultural factors* that affects human behavior.
- Cultural psychologists also examine how cultural *rules and values* (both explicit and unspoken) affect people's development, behavior, and feelings.
- This perspective holds that humans are both the products and the producers of culture, and our behavior always occurs in some cultural contexts.

Branches of Psychology

Psychology is a broad field, there are many specialization under its umbrella

Developmental Psychology

- ✓ Studies how people develop *overtime* thorough the process of maturation and learning.
- ✓ Studies age related changes through the life span
- ✓ Aspects of Development(Physical, Cognitive, Social, etc)
- ✓ Stages of Development (Infancy, Babyhood, childhood, adolescence, adulthood, old age)
- ✓ It attempts to examine the major developmental milestones that occur at different stages of development.

Cont…

Educational Psychology

- Concerned with the application of psychological principles and theories in improving the educational process including curriculum, teaching, and administration of academic programs.

Counselling Psychology

- Helps individuals with less severe problems than those treated by clinical psychologists.

✓ assists people on issues of personal adjustment, vocational and career planning, family life and may work in schools, hospitals, clinics or offices

Cont…

Personality Psychology

✓It focuses on the relatively enduring traits and characteristics of individuals.

✓Study topics such as self-concept, aggression, moral development, etc.

✓studies individual differences in personality and their effects on behaviour

Industrial(Organizational) Psychology

✓ Studies human behaviour in the workplace and how behaviour affects production

✓ Applies *psychological principles* in industries and organizations to increase the productivity of that organization.

Cont…

Social Psychology

- ✓ It studies the role of social forces in governing individual behaviour.
- ✓ Examines the ways in which the pattern of a person's feeling, thinking and acting is affected by others
- ✓ Deals with people's social interactions, relationships, social perception, and attitudes.

Cont…

Cross-cultural Psychology

- ✓ Examines the role of culture in understanding behavior, thought, and emotion.
- ✓ It compares the nature of psychological processes in different cultures, with a special interest in whether or not psychological phenomena are universal or culture-specific.

Forensic psychology

- ✓ Applies psychological principles to improve the legal system (police, testimony,etc..).

Cont…

Health Psychology

- ✓ Applies psychological principles to the prevention and treatment of physical illness and diseases.

Clinical Psychology

- ✓ Is a field that applies psychological principles to the prevention, diagnosis, and treatment of psychological disorders.

Research Methods in Psychology

Definition of Terms

- Research: Is a scientific method of gathering and testifying data by applying different methods and making conclusion and prediction of the phenomenon.
- **Theory-** is a statement which is generalized from scientific study and which explains the relationship among variables.
- It is an integrated set of principles helpful to organize, explain and predict events.

- **Hypothesis** : is any statement or assumption that serves as a possible but tentative explanation of certain observation.

- It is an educated guess that can be tested.

- It is a statement of cause and effect relationship.

- It is useful to guide a study.

Variables **:** are constructs that vary or change. There are two events or constructs. The variation of one construct may be followed by the variation of another construct.

- **Population** is a group of subjects (universe) under study.

For example, children under 5 year of age; primary school children in Sidama Zone.

- **Sample** is a small portion of a population that is expected to be representative of the population (universe). Sample is better required than population for different reasons

Cont…

Scientific method- a process of testing ideas through systematic observations, experimentations, and statistical analysis.

Theory-is an integrated set of principles about observed facts that is intended to describe and explain some aspects of experience.

Hypotheses-is a tentative proposition about the relationship between two or more variables or phenomena.

E.g. Males have high self-confidence in making decisions than females.

Major types of research methods

Descriptive research methods

- ✓ In this type of research, the researcher simply records what she/he has systematically observed.
- ✓ Include naturalistic observation, case studies, and surveys.

Correlational research methods

- ✓ Is are search method that measures the relationship between two or more variables

Experimental Research

- ✓ It is are search method that allows researchers to study the cause and effect relationship between variables

1. Naturalistic Observation

- A researcher engages in **careful observation** of behavior **without intervening** directly with the subjects.
- A research method in which various aspects of behavior carefully observed in the setting where such behavior **naturally occurs**.
- it allows researchers to study behavior under conditions that are **less artificial** than in experiments.

2. Case Study

- is an **in-depth** investigation of an individual subject.
- is an intensive study of a person or group. Most case studies combine long-term observations with **diaries**, **tests**, and **interviews**.

3. Survey

- use **questionnaires or interviews** to gather information about specific aspects of participants' background and behavior.
- One of the most practical ways to gather data on the **attitudes, beliefs, and experiences of large numbers of people** is through **surveys.**

4. Longitudinal Studies

- It studies the ***same group of people at*** regular intervals over a period of years to determine whether their behavior and/or feelings have changed and if so, how.

5. Cross-Sectional Studies

- People studied from **different age** groups at same time point.

6. Correlations

- studying the **relationship** between two variables such as between weight and height, chewing chat and score, and age and academic achievement.
- The **correlation coefficient** is a numerical index of the degree of relationship between two variables**.** A correlation coefficient indicates

  (1) the direction (positive or negative) of the RXnship

  (2) how strongly the two variables are related.

(1)

- **A *positive correlation*** indicates that two variables co-vary in the *same* direction.
- **A *negative* correlation** indicates that two variables co-vary in the *opposite* direction.

(2)

- the ***size of the coefficient*** indicates the ***strength*** of an association between two variables. The coefficient can vary between 0 and 1.00 (if positive) or between 0 and 1.00 (if negative).
- A coefficient near 0 indicates no relationship between the variables.

7. Experimental Method

- allows researchers to detect cause-and-effect relationships.
- the investigator manipulates a variable under carefully controlled conditions and observes whether any changes occur in a second variable as a result.
- There are *two types* of variables: independent and dependent.

- ***The independent variable :*** is a condition or event that an experimenter varies in order to see its impact on another variable.
- ***The dependent variable:*** is the variable that is thought to be affected by manipulation of the independent variable.

Example

1) the number of hours you study affects your performance on an exam.
2) the effect of watching violence TV program on children behavior.

- In an experiment the investigator typically assembles two groups of subjects who are treated differently with regard to the independent variable. These two groups are referred to as the experimental group and the control group.

a) The **experimental group** consists of the subjects who receive some special treatment in regard to the independent variable.

b) The **control group** consists of similar subjects who do not receive the special treatment given to the experimental group.

Steps of scientific research

Step one- Defining the Problem

- ✓ Noticing something attention catching in the surrounding for which one would like to have an explanation.

Step two-Formulating the Hypothesis

- ✓ after having an observation on surroundings (perceiving the problem),you might form an educated guess about the explanation for your observations, putting it into the form of a statement that can be tested in someway.

Cont..

Step three-Testing the Hypothesis

- ✓ At this step, the researcher employs appropriate research methods and collects ample data (information) to accept or reject the proposed statement.

Step four- Drawing Conclusions

- ✓ This is the step in which the researcher attempts to make generalizations or draw implications from tested relationship

Step five-Reporting Results

- ✓ At this point, the researcher would want to write up exactly whats he/he did, why she/he did, and what she/he found.